



**Verbatim Script Writing, Song Writing, and Costume Design:
A Four-Day Arts-based Research Methods Skills Building Workshop
June 23-26, 2025**

Theme: Building queer and trans identities, communities and allyship

Final Report





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The Workshop Leadership Team

Professor Tara Goldstein (Principal Investigator), University of Toronto, Canada

Professor Kael Reid (Co-Investigator), York University, Canada

Dr. Donna Jackson (Collaborator), Hubcap Productions, Australia

Dr. Jenny Salisbury (Guest Facilitator), University of Toronto, Canada

The Australian Youth Support Team

Amy Ferguson (Costume Design Workshop Assistant)

Lev Lu (Song Writing Workshop Assistant)

Shanti Steventon (Song Writing Workshop Assistant)

The Canadian Graduate Student Support Team

Ray Naidoo (Participant and Workshop Organization and Communication)

Siva Sivarajah (Participant and Workshop Organization and Communication)

Chloe Thierstein (Research Assistant)

Final Report

Prepared by Tara Goldstein and Chloe Thierstein

Funded by a Social Sciences and Humanities Council Connections Grant (2024-2025)

Today's date: July 25, 2025

1. Introduction

This final report brings together insights from a Four-Day Arts-Based Research Skills Development Workshop held at the Ontario Institute for Studies in Education, University of Toronto from June 23-June 26, 2025.

It draws on data from the final reflection circle takeaways and learning outcome surveys, which together offer a nuanced understanding of how participants engaged with arts-based research (ABR) as a method for building queer and trans community, practicing allyship, and developing creative research skills. The workshop included presentations from leaders in the field: Tara Goldstein, Donna Jackson, and Kael Reid, who shared how they conduct ABR through verbatim theatre, costume design, and songwriting.

2. Participant Overview

Workshop participants came from a variety of backgrounds:

- 1 undergraduate student
- 14 graduate students
- 1 early career faculty member
- 3 Australian workshop assistants
- 3 workshop leaders

Out of the 22 participants, 100% participated in the final takeaway circle and 21 completed the learning outcome survey, resulting in a 95% survey response rate.

3. Overall Outcomes of the Workshop

The four-day arts-based research skill building workshop provided participants with an opportunity to build skills in three arts-based research methods: verbatim script writing, song writing and costume design.

The international leadership team who designed and facilitated the Workshop came from Canada and Australia. They were:

- Canadian Principal Investigator Tara Goldstein from the University of Toronto (verbatim playwriting),
- Canadian Co-Investigator Kael Reid from York University (song writing) and
- Australian Collaborator Donna Jackson (costume design).

The four-day workshop also provided the leadership team with an opportunity to deepen the partnership first established in 2016 between Goldstein's theatre company Gailey Road Productions and Jackson's theatre company Hubcap productions.

The leadership team also provided three youth artists from Australia with training to support the leadership team in the delivery of the workshop.

- Amy Ferguson supported the costume design workshop while
- Lev Lu and Shanti Steventon supported the songwriter workshop.

Goldstein's colleague theatre artist Jenny Salisbury provided additional support the playwriting workshop.

Goldstein additionally provided two graduate student workshop participants, Siva Sivarajah and Ray Naidoo with workshop promotion and communication training.

Finally, Goldstein also provided graduate student Chloe Thierstein with qualitative thematic analysis training to support the analysis of focus group data from the final reflection circle take-away as well as data from a short written survey.

A summary of learning outcomes from the workshop are shared below.

4. Assessing the Learning Outcomes of the Workshop

To assess the learning outcomes from the four-day workshop, the workshop leadership team asked the following research questions:

1. What, if at all, did workshop participants learn and take away from the workshop?
2. How, if at all, will workshop participants use the knowledge they gained from the workshop?

4.1 Data Collection

To answer these questions, the research team:

1. distributed a survey which asked participants to share what they learned and how they might use the knowledge they gained going forward.
2. audio-recorded the final reflection circle take-aways on Day 4 of the workshop in which participants were asked to share what they learned and how they might use the knowledge they gained going forward.

4.2 Data Analysis

Goldstein and Thierstein analysed the data from the take-aways reflection and written surveys through thematic analysis.

Thematic analysis is a method used in qualitative research to identify, analyze, and interpret patterns of meaning within a dataset. In this case Goldstein and Thierstein looked for patterns in what the workshop participants said they learned from the four-day workshop and what they said about how they might use the knowledge they gained.

5. Findings

5. 1 The Importance of Building a Workshop Community When Sharing Queer and Trans Research

5.1.1 Community, Safety, and Collective Care

A recurring and deeply felt theme throughout the workshop was the importance of building an affirming and identity-aware community, especially as many participants shared vulnerable material rooted in queer and trans autoethnographic research. Many participants described the space as one of the first places they had felt safe enough to be both vulnerable and creative, and highlighted how care was embedded into both the workshop facilitation and feedback structures.

I feel very impressed about how vulnerable and safe I felt this week at the same time... they usually don't go together for me... [I]t's because you're so experienced and you're so generous... You were so masterful... in the way you organized everything.

The workshop environment cultivated a different kind of academic space, one that was relational and emotionally attentive, pushing back against more extractive or competitive

models of conducting research instead putting trust, empathy, and collective learning at the centre. This was particularly evident in the intentional ways workshop participants were asked to provide feedback to each other's emerging work.

For example, the same participant who spoke about feeling vulnerable and safe at the same time, had this to say about the feedback she received during the playwriting workshop:

I really appreciated seeing how we could give feedback to each other in such a meaningful and loving way. I have experienced as an editor, you know, many situations [where] ... the feedback it's violent, you know, and we have this idea that for it to be meaningful, it has to be harsh. But what I saw here was something totally different, you know, where it was meaningful, but it was kind, it was loving, it was like thinking about what the other person was doing, you know, like their process and where they wanted to, where they want to arrive to. So that was really special for me to see that and how that can be done.

When a group of workshop participants work hard to provide kind and meaningful feedback to create a supportive and kind community, people's experience in the workshop can be powerful. As Lev one of the workshop assistants said in the final take-away discussion,

... by doing things together, we can achieve a lot more than if we try to do things alone. Because for me, I find when I make content alone, sometimes I get stuck a lot because I'm just in my own head [without] being able to, like, work with different people and, you know, hear different perspectives and stuff.

For some, the workshop community that was built also offered a rare chance to “unmask” and present their authentic selves in the workshop both literally and metaphorically:

... being able to do this and like unmask, especially because I'm trans and autistic, so like, masking is a big thing. Being able to unmask, like, not just with autism, but like with trans and everything, like unmasking all the different layers of my identity and just exist safely here, it's just been really powerful for me personally, and I've been really honored to be here.

5.1.2 Confidence, Growth, and Permission to Begin

Many participants came into the workshop feeling unsure about their creative abilities and how to start an ABR project. Several participants described feeling intimidated or unsure of their “right” to do creative work in research spaces.

I usually don't try things I think I'm not good at because I don't want to make mistakes, but this workshop made me feel a little bit different because everyone made me feel secure and supported... I think that make[s] me confident.

Yet, through collective engagement with other aspiring arts-based researchers, many reported not only an increase in confidence, but also a shift in mindset. The workshop gave them permission to begin working creatively, to create without needing perfection, and to trust that their work mattered.

This process allowed me, for once in my life, [to] just be okay with a start.

This shift toward a growth mindset is particularly meaningful in academic contexts where productivity and perfection can be overvalued.

5.2 Learning ABR Methods and Seeing New Possibilities for Conducting Research

The workshop gave participants hands-on experience with songwriting, costume design, and playwriting, each grounded in ABR methodologies.

On Day One, Donna Jackson gave a presentation on how she used costume design to share queer and trans autoethnographic research (Goldstein et al., 2024).

On Day Two, Tara Goldstein gave a presentation on writing a verbatim playscript and mounting a verbatim theatre performance using archival data about queer and trans archival research (Goldstein et. al 2025).

On Day Three of the workshop Kael Reid gave a presentation on how to share autoethnographic research findings around gender identity through the creation of original songs (Reid, 2024).

The daily presentations by the workshop leaders demonstrated how ABR can be rigorous, community-based, and intellectually rich. Many participants noted that the workshops demystified ABR.

Watching the presentations, I think it became really obvious how, like, it is doable, and we can enter it even from, like, [from] having not had much experience.

Participants also learned concrete arts-based research skills such as transcribing interviews, editing monologues, coding transcripts for lyric-writing and crafting costume

pieces as visual narratives. A representative sample of these skills are listed in the chart below.

Playwriting Workshop	Song-Writing Workshop	Costume-Design Workshop	Across the three workshops
How to transcribe and write a monologue from research data. Ordering/adding additional monologues. How to create research consent forms and consider the ethics of creating a monologue from research findings.	Song writing can be collaborative. How to help guide people to put melody and music to their lyrics. How to transcribe and code transcripts for research-based song writing.	How powerful visual arts is in telling a story and sending a message. Sometimes some messages transcend words.	Stories are a great way to communicate ideas.
Research methods that lend themselves to producing verbatim theatre: • Institutional ethnography, • Brokered dialogue, • Pluriethnography, • Duo ethnography, • Autoethnography	How to incorporate different stories and perspectives into a song. Turning stories into songs.	By learning to repurpose materials I can make art more accessible for my students.	Importance of confidence and how it is okay for you to take up space.
Combining music and costume design can add further depth and meaning to verbatim theatre.			
Being open to receiving feedback. Providing constructive and meaningful feedback.			Learning from people from different walks of life.

Playwriting Workshop	Song-Writing Workshop	Costume-Design Workshop	Across the three workshops
The process of revision is necessary; work needs time to evolve.			I broadened my queer and trans connections.
Community is important to expressing ideas, frustration, anxiety and can be a form of self-care. Drawing on others' strengths and also looking for untapped strengths.			Incorporating ABR methods is not simple! It takes a lot of planning and consideration for it to be done well and safely.
			Learning how the workshop leaders built and shaped academic careers around the art they created.

In addition to learning skills to produce arts-based research, several participants in the playwriting workshop reported that they learned important methods for designing and conducting a traditional thesis project. For example, one playwriting participant appreciated the five questions Goldstein suggested students ask themselves when beginning to write up their thesis research findings.

1. What did I do?
2. Why did I do it?
3. How do I do it?
4. What did I find out?
5. What difference do it make? (Significance)

5.2.1 ABR as Healing, Political, and Necessary

For many, the workshop wasn't just an educational experience but also a healing one. Participants spoke about reclaiming stories they had once been discouraged from telling. Others shared how the ABR workshop allowed them to explore their intersectional identities (for example, queer, trans, racialized, neurodivergent) with nuance and care.

[Before the workshop] I was very discouraged [by other professors] from sharing those stories. So, to be here and then hear that people resonated with it and just like see that everyone did that too... was really nice.

5.2.2 Ethics, Accountability, and Reflexivity

A number of participants also engaged deeply with the ethical dimensions of conducting ABR. From consent protocols to the responsibility of representing participant voices, many spoke to the rigour that ABR requires, not just artistically, but ethically. The idea that ABR is not easier to conduct than traditional research, but as research that demands a different form of care, attentiveness, and researcher accountability was a repeated theme from participants.

[E]ven though we have [the story] now, it doesn't give us the right just to produce something... from it. We have to be mindful... to the participant.

Ethical feedback, the politics of representation, and researcher reflexivity were seen as central components of doing ABR well.

5.2.3 Access and Expanding the Forms of Research

Participants also reflected on how ABR offers inclusive research alternatives for expressing and accessing knowledge. For example, one of the participants described their costume as being able to tell a visual story, which could be useful.

Sometimes some message[s] transcend words.. not everyone is proficient with the words or they might not yet have the capacity to fully express their language.

This illustrates ABR's potential to broaden who can be included in academic research and what forms of knowledge can be considered legitimate by the academy.

5. 3 Intentions to undertake future arts-based research projects

Of the 14 graduate students, nine were currently working on research projects and of these participants, all nine said they would incorporate ABR into their current or future work.

The early career faculty member, all three workshop leaders, and all three assistants also plan to use ABR moving forward.

Of the five students not yet doing research, four expressed a desire to pursue future ABR work, especially in songwriting and costume design.

Additionally, 21 out of 22 participants shared an intention to continue with arts-based research, demonstrating the workshop's success in cultivating not just short-term skills, but long-term engagement. As one participant stated:

I will... [u]se art-based research for supporting and empowering the queer identities of the youth I work with.

The workshop served as a catalyst, helping participants envision how ABR could live beyond the four days and ripple into other spaces and communities.

6. In Summary

In summary, the ABR workshop was experienced as more than a research skill-building workshop. It was experienced as a space of transformation, care, and affirmation. Participants not only learned how to do ABR, but they also experienced the value of doing research in ways that are collaborative, ethical, and personally resonant. As one participant put it:

[There was a] [s]ense of community, vulnerability, and strength. [With] [s]tories of people's transformation, emerging care, empathy, and uniqueness within in[ter]sections in identity, culture, & experiences.

This speaks to the workshop's broader impact: arts-based research is more than just a method, it is a movement that enables and fosters queer and trans knowledge-making by disrupting dominant research norms and cultivates spaces rooted in care, ethics, and joy.

7. Additional achievements from the workshop

The four-day workshop facilitated by Goldstein, Reid and Jackson was organized to coincide with the work of an ethnographic songwriting project conducted by Reid.

Funded by a York University SSHRC Explore Grant project, the title of the project was *Gender creative musicking: Understanding how transgender youth use collaborative ethnographic songwriting to tell their stories*, and it produced three audio original research-based songs recorded by three youth artists: one from Ontario, Canada, and two from Melbourne, Australia.

The two youth artists from Australia were able to participate in Reid's project because of their travel from Melbourne to Toronto was funded by Goldstein's Connection Grant.

The musicking project resulted in the professional recording of three original ethnographic songs about transgender identity development:

- Song 1: We are Deities (written and recorded by Ontario youth songwriter Myles in Toronto, Canada on Dec. 23, 2024).

- Song 2 (The Noise of Sh!t (written and recorded by Melbourne youth songwriter Lev Lu in Toronto, Canada on June 21, 2025)
- Song 3: The F Word (written and recorded by Melbourne youth songwriter Shanti Steventon in Toronto, Canada on June 30, 2025).

All three songs appear on Kael Reid's website <https://kaelreid.com/> and will be used as resources in her undergraduate Child and Youth Studies courses at York University.

The weekend following the four-day workshop, Goldstein, Reid and Jackson met to provide feedback on each one of their new arts-based research projects.

- Goldstein is currently working on a verbatim playscript about her great-aunt Quebec Social Activist Léa Roback (funded by a SSHRC Insight Grant 2024-2027).
- Reid is working on the production of three original ethnographic songs about transgender identity development mentioned above (funded by a SSHRC Explore Grant 2025-2026).
- Jackson is working on a book that describes the research-based theatre projects she has designed and facilitated over the last three decades of her career as an arts-based researcher.

8. References

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